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AI



Your public ChatGPT
queries are getting
indexed by Google and
other search engines

Age ChatGPT

Update 7/31/25 4:10pm PT: Hours after this article was published, OpenAI said it [removed the feature](#) from ChatGPT that allowed users to make their public conversations discoverable by search engines. The company says this was a short-lived experiment that ultimately “introduced too many opportunities for folks to accidentally share things they didn’t intend to.” The original story follows.

It’s a strange glimpse into the human mind: If you [filter search results](#) on Google, Bing, and other search engines to only include URLs from the domain “https://chatgpt.com/share,” you can find strangers’ conversations with ChatGPT.

IMAGE CREDITS: OPENAI

Sometimes, these shared conversation links are pretty dull — people ask for help [renovating their bathroom](#), understanding [astrophysics](#), and finding [recipe ideas](#).

In another case, one user asks ChatGPT to rewrite their resume for a particular job application (judging by this person’s LinkedIn, which was easy to find based on the details in the chat log, they did not get the job). Someone else is asking questions that sound like they came out of an incel forum. Another person asks the snarky, hostile AI assistant if they can [microwave a metal fork](#) (for the record: no), but they continue to ask the AI increasingly absurd and trollish questions, eventually leading it to create a guide called “How to Use a Microwave Without Summoning Satan: A Beginner’s Guide.”

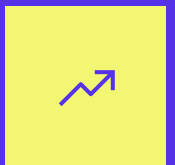
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ChatGPT does not make these conversations public by default.

A conversation would be appended with a “/share” URL only if the user deliberately clicks the “share” button on their own chat and then clicks a second “create link” button. The service also declares that “your name, custom instructions, and any messages you add after sharing stay private.” After clicking through to create a link, users can toggle whether or not they want that link to be discoverable.

However, users may not anticipate that other search engines will index their shared ChatGPT links, potentially betraying personal information (my apologies to the person whose LinkedIn I discovered).

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Though unintentional, this is a norm that was established in part by Google. When people share public links to files from Google Drive, such as documents with the “Anyone with link can view”

setting, Google may index them in Search.

However, Google generally does not surface links to Drive documents that have not been publicly posted on the web — for example, a document may appear in search if it is linked on a trusted website.

According to ChatGPT, these chats were indexed as part of an experiment.

“ChatGPT chats are not public unless you choose to share them,” an OpenAI spokesperson told TechCrunch. “We’ve been testing ways to make it easier to share helpful conversations, while keeping users in control, and we recently ended an experiment to have chats appear in search engine results if you explicitly opted in when sharing.”

While search engines like Google control the algorithms that determine what content gets surface for search terms, the search engines themselves cannot control what gets indexed.

“Neither Google nor any other search engine controls what pages are made public on the web,” a Google spokesperson told TechCrunch. “Publishers of these pages have full control over whether they are indexed by search engines.”

Updated, 7/31/25, 5:30 pm ET with comment and additional context from OpenAI.

Topics: [AI](#) [ChatGPT](#) [Google](#)



Amanda Silberling

Senior Writer |

Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...



AI



OpenAI's ChatGPT app can now search the web — but only via Bing

Kyle Wiggers — 3:04 PM PDT · June 27, 2023

IMAGE CREDITS:

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[ChatGPT](#) on mobile can now surf the web. But only via Bing.

Today, OpenAI [announced](#) that subscribers to ChatGPT Plus, the premium version of the company's AI-powered chatbot, can use a new feature on the ChatGPT app called Browsing to have ChatGPT search Bing for answers to questions.

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Browsing can be enabled by heading to the New Features section of the app settings, selecting “GPT-4” in the model switcher and choosing “Browse with Bing” from the drop-down list. Browsing is available on both the iOS and Android ChatGPT apps.

OpenAI says that Browsing is particularly useful for queries relating to current events and other information that “extend[s] beyond [ChatGPT’s] original training data.” When Browsing is disabled, ChatGPT’s knowledge cuts off in 2021.

Browsing — which Microsoft and OpenAI previously [announced](#) would arrive sometime this year, first on the web — certainly makes ChatGPT a more useful assistant, particularly for research. Prior to it, [asking ChatGPT questions](#) like “Who won the 2023 March Madness women’s tournament?” wouldn’t yield anything particularly useful — or correct.

But limiting ChatGPT’s search capabilities to Bing seems just short of a user-hostile move. The business motivations are obvious — OpenAI has a close partnership with Microsoft, which has [invested](#) over \$10 billion in the startup — but Bing is far from the be-all and end-all of search engines.

Back in 2011, an analysis found that Bing was potentially unfairly [serving](#) more Microsoft-related results than Google links. More recently, a Stanford [study](#) showed evidence that Bing’s top search results contained an “alarming” amount of disinformation.



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Microsoft undoubtedly continues to improve Bing's algorithms on the back end. But the problem with ChatGPT's new Browsing feature is, when Bing inevitably slips up, users won't have any alternatives to choose from.

In other, less controversial ChatGPT app news, tapping on a search result now takes you directly to the respective point in the conversation. That change — along with Browsing — is rolling out this week, OpenAI says.

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Kyle Wiggers

AI Editor |

Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch's AI Editor until June 2025. His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital...

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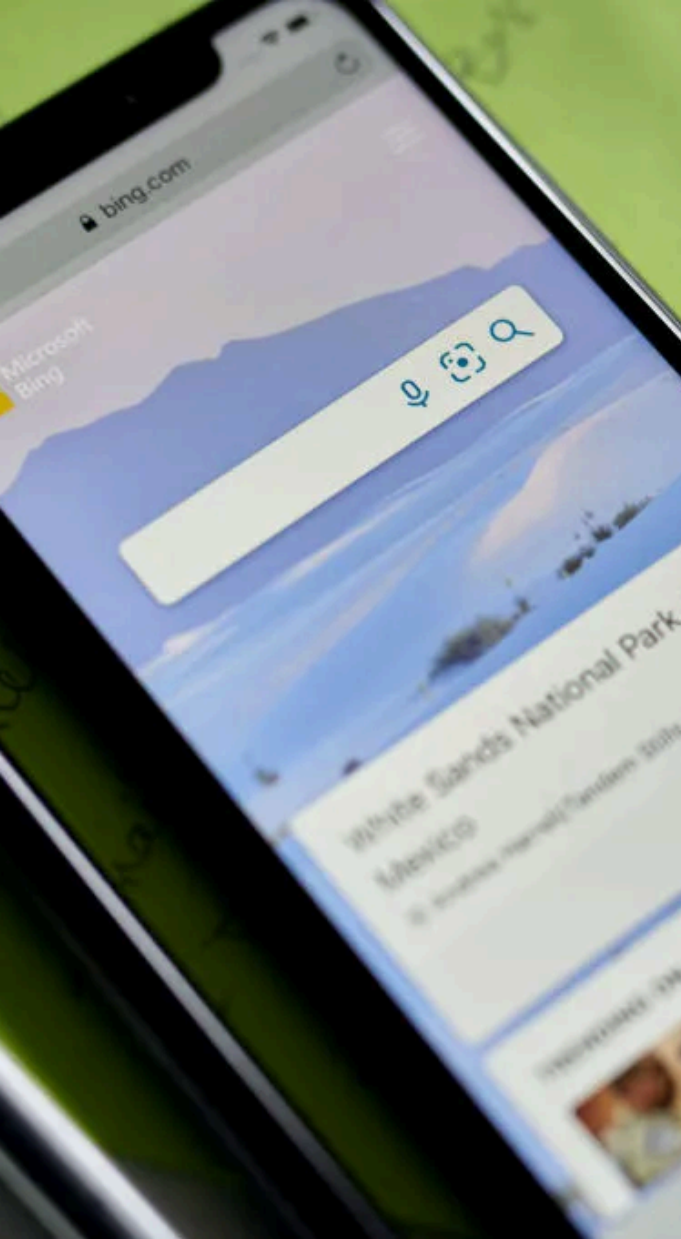


IMAGE CREDITS: [BLOOMBERG](#) / GETTY IMAGES

APPS



Bing's app sees a 10x jump in downloads after Microsoft's AI news

Sarah Perez — 9:54 AM PST · February 8, 2023

This week's news about [Microsoft's plan to add ChatGPT-like capabilities](#) to its search engine Bing has sent its companion mobile app into the App Store's Top Charts as of Wednesday. On the U.S. App Store, the Bing app has surged to the No. 12 spot among all free iPhone apps, while Microsoft's Edge browser is now the No. 3 Utility app. Globally, the Bing app has seen a 10x increase in new downloads, according to preliminary estimates from app intelligence firm [data.ai](#).

The movement indicates there's sizable consumer demand for these new AI experiences, and users are even potentially willing to try new search

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The Browser Company launches a \$20 monthly subscription for its AI-powered browser

Ivan Mehta - 2 hours ago

engines and other browsers in order to gain access.

On Tuesday, Microsoft first showed off [the new Bing.com](#) that included the highly anticipated integration of a new, [next-generation OpenAI large language model](#). The update adds a ChatGPT-like experience within the search engine itself, allowing users to converse with an AI chatbot for help with more complex queries and to aid in select content creation tasks — like writing a LinkedIn post. Microsoft also demonstrated [a new version of its Edge web browser](#) with the same AI features built into the sidebar for easy access.

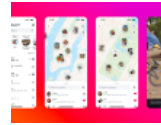
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Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

Aisha Malik - 14 hours ago

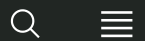
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Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik - 18 hours ago

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of users will be invited from the waitlist over the next few weeks.



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In the meantime, the company cleverly introduced a way to move up its waitlist. On a landing page, Microsoft suggests that users can gain quicker access to the new Bing if they complete a couple of additional steps. This includes setting Microsoft's search as the default on their PC and scanning a QR code to install the Microsoft Bing App on their smartphone.

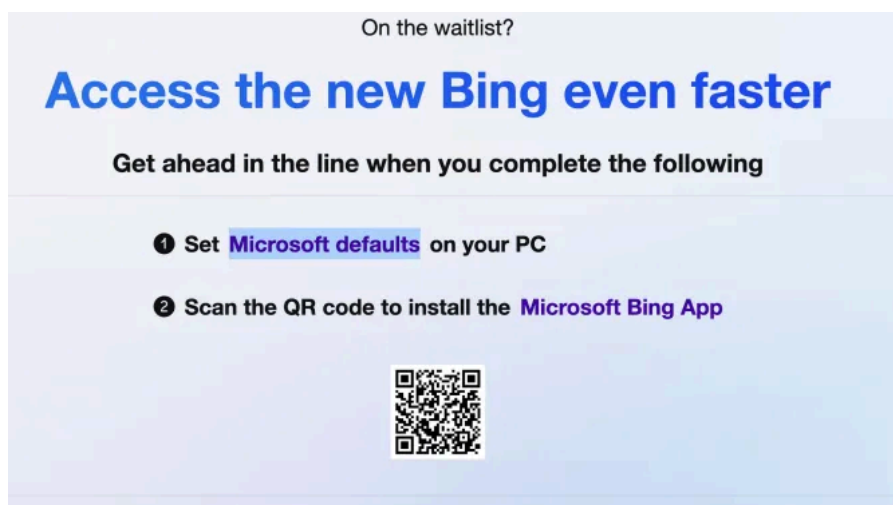


IMAGE CREDITS: BING WAITLIST WEBSITE

The latter has clearly inspired the app's rapid climb up the App Store's charts — and it's been a dramatic rise, at that.

Ahead of Microsoft's AI news, Bing was not a popular app by any stretch. As of last week, for example, the app was ranked No. 160 on the U.S. App Store's Productivity apps chart — in other words, practically invisible. It wasn't ranked on the U.S. App Store's Top Overall Charts at all. In less

than a week's time, it's nearing the top 10 in the U.S. as is the No. 2 Productivity app, as of the time of writing.



IMAGE CREDITS: DATA.AI CHART OF BING'S APP MOVEMENT

If the consumer demand wasn't there, Bing's app wouldn't have moved this significantly, despite Microsoft's push to download it.

Of course, it's worth pointing out that the App Store's charts are susceptible to being manipulated by a rush of new downloads in a compressed period of time — which is why TikTok marketing that makes apps “go viral” has become so effective. Still, the Bing app's movement is an interesting signal that demonstrates the demand for AI as well as the potential threat to Google.

Google is [already paying Apple billions per year](#) to be the default search engine in Safari. But if a large number of consumers move to another web search app like Bing or Edge in order to try out the new AI capabilities, Google could lose market share on one of the largest platforms consumers use to browse the web.

It's possible, too, that some portion of the Bing app's new users believe they'll have access to the AI features from the mobile app. To be clear, that's not yet the case as of yet. And though the app was recently updated, Microsoft makes no promises about using AI from this native iOS experience in Bing's App Store description.

In addition to downloading Bing, as prompted by Microsoft's website, some users may have downloaded Microsoft's Edge browser on their iPhone, as well. While the Edge app hasn't moved up the charts as quickly as Bing, it's now No. 3 on the U.S. App Store's Top Charts for Utilities, a slight bump from the No. 7 position it held Monday.

More specific figures around the total new installs may become available in the weeks ahead. If that's the case, we'll update with those numbers.

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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OpenAI upgrades ChatGPT search with shopping features

Maxwell Zeff — 12:03 PM PDT · April 28, 2025

Upgrade ChatGPT



OpenAI is updating [ChatGPT search](#), its web search tool in ChatGPT, to give users an improved online shopping experience, the company announced Monday.

When ChatGPT users search for products, the chatbot will now offer a few recommendations, present images and reviews for those items, and include direct links to web pages where users can buy the products. OpenAI says users can ask super-specific questions in natural language and receive customized results. To start, OpenAI is experimenting with categories such as fashion, beauty, home goods, and electronics.

OpenAI is rolling out the feature in GPT-4o (the default AI model for ChatGPT) on Monday for ChatGPT Pro, Plus, and Free users, as well as for logged-out users around the globe.

The ChatGPT search update is part of OpenAI's effort to compete with rival Google by creating a better, more personalized experience to find products and information on the internet. Online shopping is one of Google's most important businesses, but the advertising market to buy

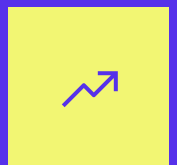
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priority placements in Google Search has also contributed to the product’s declining quality over the years.

OpenAI claims its search product is growing rapidly. Users made more than a billion web searches in ChatGPT last week, the company told TechCrunch.

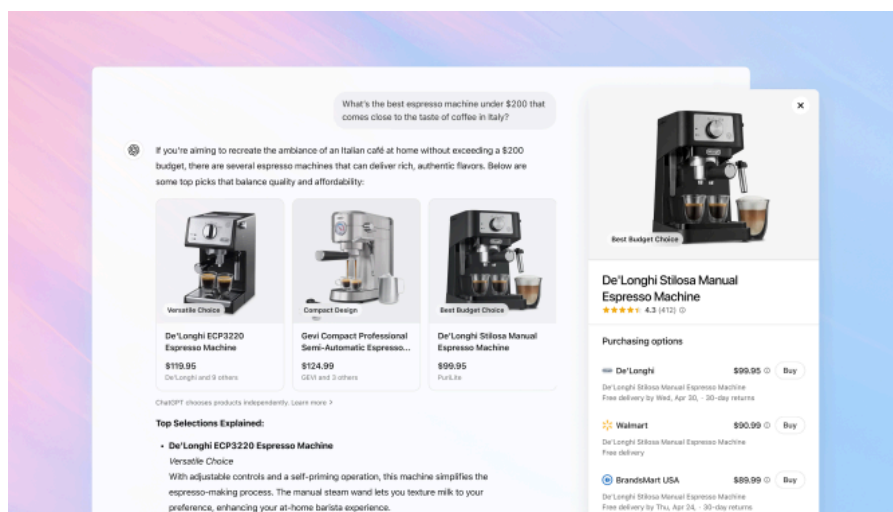


IMAGE CREDITS: OPENAI

OpenAI says it’s determining ChatGPT shopping results independently and notes that ads are not part of this upgrade to ChatGPT search. The shopping results will be based on structured metadata from third parties, such as pricing, product descriptions, and reviews, according to OpenAI. The company won’t receive a kickback from purchases made through ChatGPT search.

OpenAI CEO Sam Altman has historically been against ads in ChatGPT, but in a [recent interview](#) with Stratechery’s Ben Thompson, he changed his tune slightly. Altman said he’d be open to “tasteful” advertising in which OpenAI charges affiliate fees for purchases made through ChatGPT but doesn’t sell priority placement in their results.

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Soon, OpenAI says it will integrate [its memory feature](#) with shopping for Pro and Plus users, meaning ChatGPT will reference a user's previous chats to make highly personalized product recommendations. The company previously updated ChatGPT to [reference memory when making web searches broadly](#). However, these memory features won't be available to users in the EU, the U.K., Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, and Liechtenstein.

Alongside this update, ChatGPT search will now display trending searches when users start typing a question, much like Google Search's autocomplete feature. Additionally, ChatGPT search has come to WhatsApp, allowing users to message the company's chatbot to get up-to-date answers.

OpenAI has previously explored shopping features via its AI "agent" platform, [Operator](#), which takes anywhere from a few seconds to several minutes to browse dozens of web pages and find relevant products for users. ChatGPT search with shopping is a much faster, hands-on experience and still allows users to search for products using natural language queries.



Maxwell Zeff

Senior AI Reporter |

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg,...

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